Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> … <file>
helix -help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
v - enter select mode
3 - select 3
w - words
d - delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
wd - delete word
xc - change line
%y - yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
: - command
i - insert
v - select or extend
z - view - change view preserving selection
g - goto
m - match
Ctrl-w - window
␣ - space
[, ] - unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
u / U - undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U - move backward / forward in tree history
:ear / :lat - move backward / forward in history by step count or time span
              (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
<nn><cmd> - repeat <cmd> <nn> times
Esc - return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
:wq - write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> - write current buffer to <file> and quit
:wqa - write all buffer(s) and quit
:q - quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
:o <file> - open <file> in new buffer
:w <file> - write current buffer to <file>

:hs <file> - open/create <file> in new horizontal split
:vs <file> - open/create <file> in new vertical split
␣wf - open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
␣wF - open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
gf - open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

␣f - open file picker at LSP workspace root
␣F - open file picker at current working directory
␣g - open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
<enter> - open selected in current view
Ctrl-s - open selected in new horizontal split
Ctrl-v - open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
:n - create new scratch buffer
:bc - close current buffer
:bca - close all buffers
:bco - close all but current buffer
:bn - next buffer
␣b - open buffer picker

ga - go to last accessed/alternate buffer
gm - go to last modified/alternate buffer
gn - go to next buffer
gp - go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
␣ws / ␣wv - split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
␣wns / ␣wnv - split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
␣wq - close current split
␣wo - close all but current split
␣ww - next split
␣wh/j/k/l - move to buffer left / up / down / right
␣wH/J/K/L - swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
␣wt - tranpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
Z - enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

zz, zc - align to center
zt - align to top
zb - align to bottom
zm - align to middle horizontally
zj - scroll down
zk - scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
:tutor - open tutorial
␣? - open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
h/j/k/l - left / up / down / right
gh, g| - beginning of line
<nn>g| - column <nn>
gl - end of line
gg - top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g - line <nn>
ge - bottom of file
gw - two-char labels on words, label to go to word

g.- to last modification in current file
gj - down textual line
gk - up textual line

gs - first non-white-space char
gt - top of screen
gc - middle of screen
gb - bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
gd - go to definition
gy - go to type definition
gr - go to references
gi - go to implementation

]d - next diagnostic
[d - prior diagnostic
]D - last diagnostic
[D - first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f - to next, prior function
]t, [t - to next, prior type definition
]T, [T - to next, prior test
]a, [a - to next, prior arg
]c, [c - to next, prior comment
]g, [g - to next, prior change
]G, [G - to last, first change

Alt-e - move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b - move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b - page up
Ctrl-f - page down
Ctrl-u - half page up
Ctrl-d - half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
% - select whole file
Alt-; - swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: - selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
Alt-o - expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i - shrink selection
; - collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> - match around / inside the object indicated by <ch>
                  below:
w / W - word / WORD
p - paragraph
(, [, ', etc. - specified surround pairs
m - closest surround pair
f - function
t - type or class
a - argument/parameter
c - comment
T - test
g - change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W - to start of next word / WORD
e / E - to end of current word / WORD
b / B - to start of current word / WORD
x - current line, extend by line
X - extend to line
Alt-x - shrink to line bounds
]p - to next paragraph
[p - to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o - expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i - shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p - select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n - select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a - select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I - select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> - to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> - to <ch> exclusive (till)
Alt-.  - repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v - toggle select mode
Esc - return to normal
) - cycle primary selection forward
( - cycle primary selection backward
Alt-,  - remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> - matches become selections
S - split on match
Alt-s - split on newlines
C, Alt-C - add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
& - align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> - merge selections
Alt-<under> - merge consecutive selections
,  - remove all except primary selection
Alt-,  - remove primary selection
( / ) - rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) - rotate content backward / forward
K - keep selections matching the regex
Alt-K - remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
i - before selection
a - after selection
I - at start of line
A - at end of line
o - add line and insert below cursor
O - add line and insert above cursor
Esc - end insert (return to normal)
. - repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
]␣ - newline below
[␣ - newline above
ms<ch> - add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
d - selection -> yank buf, delete selection
Alt-d - delete, no save
md<ch> - delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
c - selection -> yank buf, change selection
Alt-c - change, no save
= - format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> - replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> - Indent line(s) containing selection
< - Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
~ - change case
` - set lowercase
Alt-` - set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c - Toggle comment
␣C - Toggle block comment
␣Alt-C - Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a - increment the selected number
Ctrl-x - decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
J - join lines in a selection
Alt-J - join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
<under> - trim whitespace from selection
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
y - selection -> yank buf
p - paste yank buf after the cursor
P - paste yank buf before the cursor
␣y - yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
␣Y - yank main selection -> system clipboard
␣p / ␣P - paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
␣R - replace selection(s) with clipboard
r<ch> - replace selection with <ch>
R - replace selection with yank buf
" - select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
/<regex> - search forward for regex
?<regex> - search backward for regex
n, N - next, previous match
* - search for current selection, respect word boundaries
Alt-* - search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
"<ch> - change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y - yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p - paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R - replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q - toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q - play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s - save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i - move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o - move backwards in jumplist
␣j - open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm - go to matching delim
mi<ch> - match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch> - match around delim <ch>
ms<ch> - add delim <ch> around selection
md<ch> - delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> - replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
| - replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| - ignore output
! - insert output before each selection(s)
Alt-! - append output after each selection(s)
$ - keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G - debug - experimental
␣k - show documentation for item under cursor
␣s - open document symbol picker
␣S - open workspace symbol picker
␣d - open document diagnostics picker
␣D - open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r - rename symbol
␣a - apply code action
␣h - select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open - open the config file
:config-open-workspace - open the workspace config file
:config-reload - reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' - open last picker
␣/ - open global search in workspace folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
Ctrl-s - commit undo checkpoint
Ctrl-x - autocomplete
Ctrl-r - insert a register content
Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> - delete previous word
Alt-d, Alt-<del> - delete next word
Ctrl-u - delete to start of line
Ctrl-k - delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> - delete previous char
Ctrl-d, <del> - delete next char
Ctrl-j, <enter> - insert new line

<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> - usual meaning but discouraged
<PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
Esc, Ctrl-c - close prompt
<enter> - open selected
<tab> - select next completion item
<backtab> - select previous completion item
Alt-b - backward a word
Ctrl-b - backward a char
Alt-f - forward a word
Ctrl-f - forward a char
Ctrl-e - to prompt end
Ctrl-a - to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> - delete previous word
Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> - delete next word
Ctrl-u - delete to start of line
Ctrl-k - delete to end of line
<bksp>, Ctrl-h - delete previous char
<del>, Ctrl-d - delete next char
Ctrl-s - insert a word under doc cursor (may be
         changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
Ctrl-p - select previous history
Ctrl-n - select next history
Ctrl-r - insert the content of the register selected by
         following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> - previous entry
<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> - next entry
<Home> - to first entry
<End> - to last entry
Ctrl-u, <PageUp> - page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown> - page down
<enter> - open selected
Alt-<enter> - open selected in the background without
              closing the picker
Ctrl-s - open horizontally
Ctrl-v - open vertically
Ctrl-t - toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c - close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u - scroll up
Ctrl-d - scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p - previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n - next entry
<enter> - close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c - close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p - previous signature
Alt-n - next signature
```